13. Sanctuary

At first glance, anyone pausing in the lane to look across the adjoining field on a mild evening in early summer would have concluded the pressure of international cricket had finally got to me. There I was, walking in a circle, gesticulating wildly and shouting ‘Baa’ at a flock of around 200 sheep.

As hard as this is to believe, there was method in my apparent madness. Baa was a pet lamb that came running at the sound of its name. He slept in the house alongside Bonnie, the black Labrador, his companion on a daily basis around the house. Baa lived in the garden until he began to eat the flowers and was banished to the field.

I know, I couldn’t get my head around it either.

Baa came with the territory when I first met Alice and stopped off in Bedfordshire on the way to training sessions in Loughborough, or to play squash with friends in the area. We had started seeing each other in my final year at school (Alice was in the year below), and we had kept in touch in our gap years, when she went travelling and I played grade cricket in Australia.

We began spending more time together, as she prepared to go to Reading University and my cricket career gathered momentum. The farm visits were just to see Alice as I didn’t have much interest in agriculture at the time and had never had dogs at home in Essex, but I enjoyed the tranquillity of long country walks. It must have looked weird, a lamb trotting alongside a Labrador without a care in the world, but it represented a strange normality.